

DELHI | Fair Frontiers

Women have broken into another male-dominated territory, in this case the rugged 3,488-km India-China border. The first batch of 366 women Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) personnel are in the last stages of their 44-week training, comprising mountaineering, field craft, weapon handling and unarmed combat at the ITBP training facility in Haryana.

The first batch of 209 personnel will be ready for deployment in March. Last year, the BSF became the first force to deploy women personnel on the Indo-Pakistan border in Punjab but the ITBP deployments will test the physical limits of the women: the force is currently deployed from the Karakoram



WOMEN RECRUITS AT A TRAINING SESSION

Pass in Ladakh to Diphu La in Arunachal Pradesh, manning border outposts at heights from 9,000 to 18,500 ft along the India-China border. An ITBP official said the need for women personnel was most needed "largely for frisking duties along border trading outposts, like the one at Nathu La". *by Sandeep Unnithan*

Power Play

Six ministers in the United Progressive Alliance Government, including senior Congressmen, are lobbying for change in their portfolio and four ministers of state have petitioned their parties to negotiate their promotion to cabinet rank.

BHOPAL | A Question of Caste



First it was gender and now it is caste that stands in the way of a eunuch mayor. Kamla Jaan had created waves in 2000 when she became the first eunuch mayor in India taking over in Katni, Madhya Pradesh. Now, almost a decade later, another town in Madhya

KAMLA BUA IS FELICITATED

Pradesh, Sagar, has elected another eunuch, Kamla Bua, as its mayor. But just like her famous predecessor's victory, Bua's election too was immediately challenged. The 54-year-old independent candidate had defeated her nearest BJP rival by a margin of over 43,000 votes. A retired chief municipal officer has now challenged Bua's election in the Sagar district and sessions court, saying she stated her caste as 'Kinnar-Kori', which was not on the list of Scheduled Castes. But the savvy Bua had already approached the district as well as high court with a caveat in anticipation of just such a move. *by Ambresh Mishra*

JAIPUR | Case Study

It is a judicial decision which has taken politics out of action. The Rajasthan High Court on January 4 ordered the Rajasthan Government to transfer all cases being investigated by the N.N. Mathur Commission to the Lokayukta. Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot had set up the Mathur Commission to



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investigate whether prima facie corruption took place in land deals during his predecessor Vasundhara Raje's tenure. During its year-long functioning, the three-member commission scanned thousands of papers and summoned many officials but did not arrive at any decision. Acting on a PIL, the high court questioned whether the investigation could be an indication of a political vendetta against the previous government. The handover of such a sweeping inquiry to the Lokayukta may now cause discomfort to the Gehlot Government.

by Rohit Parihar